



HIS MANY FACES
(clockwise from left) Tovino Thomas; the actor in *Minnal Murali*; and in *Kala*

centred, juvenile guy to someone who becomes selfless," says Tovino. "It's a gradual change, and I had to think like the character: if someone like him gets a superpower, he won't go out and start saving people immediately, he will just be excited. To show him evolving, that's what made it worthwhile as an actor."

The setting is atypical for the genre, and the story builds in mundane, unglamorous ways: Jaison tests his powers by juggling kitchen utensils; clumsily, he discovers that flying is not one of his new gifts. In one scene, Tovino—named the most desirable man from Kerala in a 2018 listing—even appears to send up his image as a style icon: wearing an "Abibas" shirt, he goes "Stylish, right?" It's one of many scenes that make *Minnal Murali* an unusual and charming superhero movie.

It's clear that director Basil Joseph and Tovino set out to make the film very rooted. "That came naturally. Basil and I are small-town boys. I did *Godha* (2017) with him, we became good friends; I can see it on his face when I give a good performance. Also, we both have kids inside us. We don't want to grow up!" With their budgets, they couldn't do a Marvel-style film anyway, he adds—"and you can't have superheroes flying around skyscrapers in Kerala. We wanted it to be relatable, so even the transformation is caused by a natural force. We used practical effects instead of VFX, and emphasised emotions and character development, which is what Malayalam cinema is known for."

Equally central to *Minnal Murali's* old-world charm is that it isn't set in a technology-saturated present. This is made clear by the wall posters and a *Chitrahaar* reference. "We thought of it as unfolding in 1994-95. It would have been a very different film if it had mobile phones or the internet."

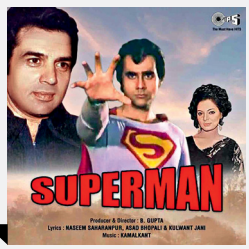
Joseph and Tovino, though, don't want to be rigid when making future *Minnal Murali* films. "We passed the first exam, the character's origin story—after this we can take more liberties, maybe change the setting." Tovino also hopes the film will get more viewers interested in Malayalam movies. "We in Kerala watch French and Korean movies, so why can't people watch our work?" ■

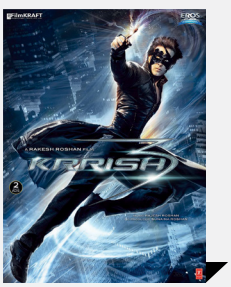
–Jai Arjun Singh

GUARDIANS OF OUR GALAXY

Indian superhero movies down the years

SUPERMAN
(1987)
Before playing Duryodhana on TV, Puneet Issar played the title role in this entertaining B-movie, a rip-off of the Christopher Reeve *Superman*. With Dharmendra as the Jor-El character, declaring "*Yeh dharti meri maa hai*" as his planet is about to blow up!





KRRISH 3
(2013)
Arguably the most enjoyable entry in the "Krrish franchise" that began with *Koi Mil Gaya*, this film gets much of its energy from Hrithik Roshan—one of our most superhero-appropriate stars—fully inhabiting the title role.

A FLYING JATT
(2016)
This sweet-natured film about a Sikh superman (played by Tiger Shroff) could have been more fun if it had stuck with its initially goofy tone throughout, instead of trying to replicate every trope of the western superhero film.

